

Lesson 3: Roadblocks for Women in Leadership

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If you're like many organizations, you may have several women in key leadership positions at your company. You might look at the legacy of female board members or C-suite executives and think, "Hey, we're getting there!"

The problem is, despite decades of being *in* the workforce, women are having a much harder time reaching and staying at the upper levels of leadership.

And the problem trickles down to C-Suites and corporate boardrooms all over America.

Again...*why?*

Well, experts have a variety of theories. One is a "leak in the pipeline." One is expectations around traditional gender roles. Women often face stereotypes that label them as "less competent" or less suited for leadership roles compared to men – hence the old adage of "having to work twice as hard to be thought of as half as good."

You know I remember so many times myself as an AD would be sitting in a boardroom and I would be the only female in the room. Somebody said, "How do you do it?"

"One, I was more prepared. Two I wanted to fit in and be part of the discussion, so I just didn't hide at the back of the room."

I remember one time we were negotiating television contracts – *big* money contracts. I was the only woman in the room, and a gentleman comes in to do his presentation, and he says, "You guys...and Joan." And then he goes on to give his proposal. I took a deep breath, and I said to myself, "OK."

Then, a second gentleman comes in the room and says, "You guys...and Joan." That's when I called timeout, and I said, "Let's talk about this."

I said, "I am here to make a decision just like everybody else. It never bothered me to be called 'you guys' in a setting like this. I never coached 'woman-to-woman' defense, I always coached man-to-man. So be sure you don't try to point out the difference in men and women sitting around the board table because you're all there to do the same job."

To be seen as competent, women need to project confidence and assertiveness, but are often stereotyped as "unfeminine" or "aggressive" when they do, stereotypes their male counterparts don't encounter when advancing their own careers.

Some include organizational barriers – ingrained practices and policies that inadvertently favor men, such as 8-5:00 working hours that weren't designed for parents who had to pick up children from school. Or male-dominated industries where women are constantly having to perform as minority players.

Then, there's a lack of mentorship – a lack of other females who have been in leadership positions to show the way, leaving women to be groomed by men who might have had an entirely different set of career struggles than they have along the way.

In the upcoming lesson, we'll take a look at some of these examples and more.